

Photographs by SHAILESH RAWAL

As even more archaeological evidence pops up in the Taranga Hills, Gujarat finds more reason to proclaim its Buddhist links



Buddha CONNECTION

By Uday Mahurkar

Over the past 900 years Taranga has remained the most revered spot for the Jain community. Located in the Aravalli range, which begins in north Gujarat, it boasts of medieval and early medieval Jain temples amongst which stands the majestic Ajitnath temple. It was built by the Solanki ruler Kumarpal who believed in Jain tenets and was a disciple of legendary Jain saint Hemchandrasuri in the 12th century. Possibly the tallest temple in India, Ajitnath temple is a monument of exquisite beauty. For Jain pilgrims and lovers of ancient Indian architecture, Taranga, which comprises low-ranged hills, is a favoured spot. Now, it is set to attract attention for a different but equally important reason, historically speaking. Archaeologists have found conclusive evidence that the western side of the Taranga Hills is the seat of a comprehensive Buddhist settlement dating back to the 3rd century B.C. The new discovery comes close on the heels of that of a

Buddhist monastery in Vadnagar, located 20 km from Taranga, underlining the state's position as a major Buddhist destination.

Another major revelation was the town named Anartapur that has been often wrongly confused with Anandpur (modern Vadnagar as it was called 2,000 years ago) is actually the south-eastern part of the Taranga Hills, containing the Jain temples. The biggest indication of this is the discovery of a 2,000-year-old fort wall that was hidden from archaeologists due to dense vegetation on and around it, resulting in researchers never venturing beyond the medieval fort wall. The Gwalior Prasasti of Gurjar Pratihar king Mihir Bhoja (836-885 A.D.) says that his

predecessor Nagabhatta II (792-834 A.D.) had conquered the Giri Durga fort of Anartapur in Gujarat which was believed to be Anandpur. But the land grants issued via *tamrapatras* by the Maitraka rulers before 648 A.D. clearly indicate that both Anartapur and Anandpur were different towns.

The Buddhist discovery comes as a boon to Gujarat which has been trying to sell itself as a Buddhist destination. Archaeologists led by Y.S. Rawat, who discovered the Buddhist monastery in Vadnagar, have found natural rock caves and shelters where the monks lived, broken terracotta images of Lord Buddha, stone and even brick walls inside rock shelters, remains of the embankment of a water reservoir of that period and terraces or platforms facing each rock shelter made of stones, mud and even bricks at some places on the western side of Taranga. What is most interesting is a cave found atop one of the three hills, Jogida, where Rawat discovered four carved images of the Dhyani Buddha on a stone plate, a place he believes the head monk lived. It is spread over the slopes

BROKEN STATUES OF THE BUDDHA IN THE PADMASANA POSTURE

